

What's Cooking?

RealSystem iQ by RealNetworks points to the future of media delivered via the Internet. It is preparing itself for a future when video-on-demand, gaming networks, and broadcasting to wireless devices become commonplace. RealSystem iQ uses a distributed architecture that can deliver digital media-to-media networks and even consumer devices beyond the PC. For more information on RealSystem iQ, you can log on to www.real.com.

Active Streaming Format (ASF) is Microsoft's offering to the streaming media world. ASF files can be played locally, over the network or over the Internet while maintaining the quality of the picture and/or sound. The small size of ASF files lends itself easily to medium quality video clips being transported over long distances. Microsoft has also released Windows Media 8, which can be used for streaming as well as for downloads. It has a compression efficiency of an additional 30 per cent over Windows Media 7 and offers near-VHS quality at 250 Kbps, and near-DVD quality at 500 Kbps. Windows Media 8 comes with Digital Rights Management, which can be a form of succour to the movie industry plagued with rampant piracy.



Streaming it Thru



Streaming technology enables you to watch a video while it downloads. This means that you need not download the full movie to see it, which is a great relief for the low-bandwidth users. Streaming is done as shown in the figure. First the movie frames that are to be relayed are created and they are put on a server for digitisation and compression. This process could be called encoding or just compression. The compressed movie is sent to the media server which acts as the base, from which the user requests movie clips for viewing. The streaming audio and video could be relayed as and when requested or it could be a live relay. For the live relay, the media server and the compression at the encoding server has to be extremely fast, so that the user finds no delay in frame relay

up a DivX-encoded movie on a Web site. They are either available as one big chunk in one of those free drive areas or available as 25 MB chunks which could be downloaded and combined to frame a full-length movie. But this is likely to change soon. Jerome Rota, a 27-year-old Frenchman, the mind behind DivX, is preparing to release a complete, legal version of the video and audio encoding technology that does not require the use of Microsoft's MPEG-4 Codec. You would then be able to download movies from the Internet, if they are released legally over the Net.

Another project that is working towards an open standard version of the complicated compression technology—OpenDivX, is Mayo. Mayo believes that there has to be an open standard that's independent of any existent technology and this has resulted in OpenDivX. DivX Deux was released as OpenDivX on January 15, 2001. This is an open standard, so anyone interested in DivX can register, have a peek at the code, analyse it and submit suggestions for the enhancement of the project.

According to the developers at Project Mayo, "The Project Mayo vision is a world of standard video technologies that deliver mind-blowing, stunning visual quality, and a wide set of tools and applications on a variety of platforms..."

Stux, the brain behind the DivX player for Mac, and his team are working on a new DivX Codec called 3ivX. The team claims that their Codec is going to be a

A clip from the sports site of ESPN, which allows the user to pick the connection speed so that he can view the highlights or the full video of a particular series or game

fully open source Codec and will be optimised, so that the file size is considerably reduced with no compromise on quality. But the most important part of the 3ivX is that it will be fully streamable. As DivX is not streamable in its present state, 3ivX would surely gain popularity.

3ivX targets wired and wireless markets such as movie distribution, set-top-boxes, video-on-demand, video conferencing, Internet TV, in-flight entertainment, game consoles, etc. Besides, 3ivX is multi-platform, so the same file can be viewed on all OSes. The team also claims that services like Digital Rights Management, encryption, and payment systems are all possible. This would in a way aid the movie industry to choose the appropriate digital wagon to distribute movies on a pay-per-view basis.

Hold the popcorn yet!

Download movies? Sounds great, except for one thing. Is your connection up to it? Bandwidth is the main issue as far as downloading movies from the Web is concerned. For a mere 1 MB mail over a dial-up connection the average user keeps his fingers crossed. So you can imagine what will happen if you try downloading a DivX movie. At least for now, DivX movies are meant for users who use ISDN, cable or T1 lines.

Besides, all said and done, one simply cannot ignore the issue of copyright and other legalities involved with downloading DivX. Hollywood is facing the same issues plaguing the music industry and it's facing them sooner than it expected. The software program that is turning out to be the source of Hollywood's digital headache is DivX. The movie industry is waging an aggressive legal battle to protect its copyrights. The Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA) recently joined hands with the recording